



M/J Critical Thinking Skills

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · COURSE SYLLABUS · 2026–2027

Full Year · Grades 6–8

FACILITATOR

Optima Academy Online Faculty

FLORIDA COURSE

Florida 1700100 · Full-year course

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 6–8 (Middle School)

EMAIL & OFFICE

Your facilitator's email is posted in Canvas · 239.673.2801 (OAO Front Office)

OFFICE HOURS

Posted in Canvas · weekly study hall and VR workshops

FORMAT

On-Demand (also offered live on the VR campus)

About this syllabus. This is the plan for the course as designed. It is a full-year middle-school course; On-Demand scholars pace through the five modules across the four quarters of their enrolled year. On-Demand and live-school sections share the same content and expectations; exact pacing, scheduled dates, and a few activities may vary from section to section and term to term. Your facilitator will confirm the specifics for your section.

COURSE OVERVIEW

M/J Critical Thinking Skills teaches scholars to think, read, reason, and argue like an intellectual. Across five modules, scholars move from the practical habits of a serious student — time management, goal-setting, active reading, note-taking, memory, and test preparation — to the deeper work of clear communication, scientific reasoning, close reading, and well-built argument. The work is hands-on: every topic pairs a short interactive lesson with a written assignment and an immersive activity on Optima's VR campus, and three of the modules build toward a real project that scholars complete and present — a week-long Good Life Experiment, an annotated bibliography assembled in a VR research library, and a final Disputatio in which they research a debate and defend a position of their own. The course assumes that learning to reason well is a skill worth practicing for its own sake and for every subject and decision that follows.

WHAT SCHOLARS WILL LEARN TO DO

- Apply study skills — time management, goal-setting, active reading, note-taking, memory, and test preparation — to manage their own learning.
- Communicate clearly and adapt how they communicate to different people, purposes, and situations.
- Tell facts from opinions and recognize when a claim is substantive rather than mere opinion.
- Reason scientifically: form hypotheses, gather and evaluate evidence, and calibrate their confidence in a belief.
- Identify faulty reasoning and common logical fallacies.
- Read closely and critically — previewing, questioning, inferring, summarizing, and synthesizing across sources.
- Find, evaluate, and cite sources with academic integrity.
- Build, evaluate, and refine an argument, and defend a position against counter-arguments.

BIG PROJECTS & MILESTONES

The course builds toward a set of finished, real-world artifacts. Target dates below follow a **sample full-year pacing**; On-Demand scholars pace to their own enrolled term and Live sections follow the class schedule, keeping each milestone roughly in order.

PROJECT / MILESTONE	COURSE PLACE	SAMPLE TARGET	WHAT YOU TURN IN
The Good Life Experiment	Module 3 · Weeks 14–24	by Feb 26 (Q3)	A week-long self-experiment with a daily data log and a findings video in science-paper format, submitted in Canvas.
Annotated Bibliography	Module 4 · Weeks 25–32	by Apr 30	A curated set of sources, evaluated and annotated inside a VR research library, with a guided tour.
The Disputatio (course final)	Module 5 · Weeks 33–36	by May 21	A researched argument built and defended in a VR arena: a position taken, counter-arguments answered, and claims fact-checked.

IMPORTANT DATES — 2026–2027

Aug 12, 2026	First day of school	Sep 7	Holiday (Labor Day)
Oct 9	Quarter 1 ends	Oct 12	Holiday (Columbus Day)
Nov 11	Holiday (Veterans' Day)	Nov 23–27	Thanksgiving break
Dec 18	Quarter 2 ends · fall semester ends	Dec 21–Jan 1	Winter break
Jan 5, 2027	Classes resume	Jan 18	Holiday (MLK Day)
Feb 15	Holiday (Presidents' Day)	Mar 5	Quarter 3 ends
Mar 26–Apr 5	Spring break	Apr 6	Classes resume
May 28, 2027	Quarter 4 ends · last day of school	May 31	Holiday (Memorial Day)

ASSESSMENT & GRADING

50%

Weekly written assignments

30%

Module projects & the Disputatio final

20%

VR campus activities

HOW THIS COURSE IS DELIVERED

This course is offered in two formats that share the same content, assignments, and expectations: an **On-Demand (asynchronous)** section you pace yourself, and a **Live (synchronous)** section that meets on a schedule on Optima's VR campus. The two overviews below explain how each one works. Find the one that matches your enrollment.

ON-DEMAND (ASYNCHRONOUS) LEARNING

In the **On-Demand** section you move through the course at your own pace within each quarter, guided by due dates that keep you on track. All assignments for a quarter open at its start and close at its end. Because the course is On-Demand, there is no grade penalty for missing an individual due date — but any assignment not completed by the end of the quarter receives a **zero**, and assignments submitted in the final **14 days** of a quarter receive a **10% deduction**, so steady pacing matters.

Attendance is measured by assignment completion. Per school policy, a scholar who completes no assignment for ten consecutive school days, without notifying the school of an absence in advance, may be dropped from the course. Completion means a **sincere attempt** — real effort on real work. Rushed work, wrong or corrupted files, irrelevant or nonsense submissions, AI-generated filler, and word-salad responses do not count.



You are never on your own. A live facilitator grades your work, gives feedback, and hosts a weekly study hall and VR workshops.

LIVE (SYNCHRONOUS) LEARNING

In the **Live** section you join scheduled class meetings on Optima's VR campus, where your teacher leads instruction in real time and you learn alongside classmates. The readings, assignments, and projects are the same as the On-Demand course; what differs is the pacing — a Live section moves through the material together on the class schedule rather than at each scholar's own pace, and class time is also used for discussion, questions, and guided practice.

Attendance is measured by presence and participation. You are expected to attend the scheduled live sessions, on time and ready to take part. If you must miss a class, notify the school in advance; your teacher will let you know how to make up the work and any material you missed. As in every Optima course, completing your work means a **sincere attempt** — real effort on real work — and assignments still open and close with each quarter.



You meet regularly with a teacher. The class gathers throughout the week in VR and on Microsoft Teams for live instruction and discussion.

APPROPRIATE USE OF AI

Optima scholars are preparing for a world shaped by artificial intelligence, and learning to use these tools with good judgment is part of that preparation. You are welcome to use AI tools to **support** your learning — to explain a concept a different way, check your understanding, or brainstorm — unless a particular assignment says otherwise. What AI may **never** do is the thinking or the work an assignment asks of you: a reflection, a self-assessment, a resume, an essay, or a discussion post must be genuinely your own. Submitting AI-generated text as if it were your own work is dishonest and, as noted above, counts as an insincere attempt. When you do use an AI tool on an assignment, say so briefly. Above all, build the underlying skill yourself — the goal is for you to be able to judge whether an AI's answer is any good, which you can only do if you can do the work without it.

LEARNING IN VIRTUAL REALITY

Optima is a virtual-reality school. Alongside your Canvas coursework, you will join immersive sessions on Optima's VR campus, where you meet teachers and fellow scholars, take part in live activities, and explore places and ideas you could not visit in an ordinary classroom. Keep your headset charged and ready for any scheduled VR sessions, and treat the VR campus with the same courtesy and seriousness you would a physical one. If you ever cannot get into VR for a session, tell your facilitator — there is an alternative way to take part so you do not fall behind.

BEING AN OPTIMA SCHOLAR

Optima's mission is an excellent, virtue-centered education, and virtue is at the center of this course as much as any other. Every scholar is expected to practice the seven virtues that shape life at Optima — **courage, courtesy, honesty, perseverance, self-government, service, and responsibility**. In practice that means: do your own honest work; treat everyone you meet in, through, or because of this course with respect, in writing, in discussion, and in VR; engage actively rather than passively; come to office hours to get help, meet other scholars, and get to know your facilitator; and take responsibility for your own pacing and progress. You belong to a house and a community of scholars, not only to a course.

WHAT YOU NEED & STAYING CONNECTED

- ✓ A computer with reliable internet and access to **Canvas**.
- ✓ A **VR headset**, charged and ready for the weekly immersive activities on Optima's VR campus.
- ✓ **Microsoft 365** (Word, Excel) with OneDrive, for the documents and data logs you create and submit.
- ✓ A notebook or binder, and pens or pencils, for notes and study practice.

Staying connected. Updates about this course are posted on the course's **Canvas** page; school-wide updates are posted in your **Homeroom Canvas** course. Check both regularly. Your facilitator holds office hours and is glad to help with the material, to meet you, or to talk through your plans — come by, or reach out any time by email.